’Tis New to Thee

2026

Huxley Returns to the Brave New World.
A Re-creation

A FORETASTE



ESSAH

A FORETASTE · A FIVE-MINUTE READ

The first day and the last, from the essay of the same title

I died on the 22nd of November 1963, in Los Angeles, on an afternoon when the world had more important things to attend to. In Dallas a President had been shot, and beside such an event the death of an ageing novelist looked much as a falling leaf looks beside an earthquake. I have never held it against the world. I thought it a fitting punchline for a man who had spent half his life asking what human beings pay attention to, and why so rarely to the things that matter.

How I came to return I shall not attempt to explain. I am sitting in an express train somewhere in the middle of Germany, second class, and for the first time since my boyhood I am able to see clearly. At sixteen an inflammation of the cornea left me very nearly blind. There is a certain irony in the fact that a half-blind man should have been celebrated for his foresight.

So I can see. And this is what I see.

Some sixty passengers are sitting in this carriage, and almost every one of them holds his head inclined at an angle I had previously observed only in monks at their office: the neck bowed, the hands before the breast,

the eyes lowered upon a small rectangle which, unlike a breviary, is lit from within. Outside, water meadows drift past in the mist. A heron stands in the shallows with the indifference of an aristocrat; a church tower rises out of the haze like an exclamation mark without a sentence. Nobody looks out. I count: nobody.

I spent a lifetime trying to push open the doors of perception. They have been bricked up, a window has been set into the brickwork, and the window has been declared a television.

Then the young man next to me slides his thumb across his device, and for the space of a blink I see my own name. Above it stands a sentence I never wrote, set against a sunset in that shade of orange which is rare in nature and common on soft-drink cans. He lingers on me for perhaps a second. Then comes a cat.

And at that moment it wells up in me, warm, sweet, almost physical: *I told you so.* I know this feeling. It is the oldest intoxicant of mankind, and it has only one side effect: it makes you blind. I know what I am talking about. I have been blind before. So before I reproach anyone with what I saw coming, I mean to open a ledger, not of other people's errors, but of my own. It will not, I fear, remain empty.

What followed I tell from memory. At the station where I alighted I wished to use the free network, and it asked me to accept its terms and conditions. I began to read. After four minutes I had managed one twentieth. A man in a suit pressed *Accept* without looking. No tyrant in history ever brought his subjects to the point of putting on their own chains while signing a form to confirm that they had done so of their own free will.

In a library I searched for the secret behind it all and found something more disquieting: there was none. The great companies speak openly in their annual reports about human attention, as mining companies speak of a coal seam. One has only to read them. But the reports run to two hundred pages, and boredom guards them more reliably than any secret service.

In the evening I sat in a tavern. A man at the bar lowered his voice and hinted that quite other people were really pulling the strings. I knew that lowered voice from the cafés of the thirties, and I knew where it leads. At the table behind us some young people were laughing at an aunt who had thought the wrong thoughts during the plague and to whom they no longer spoke. When I turned round, I saw on their faces the same little gleam as on my neighbour's at the bar. The villains were different. The pleasure in them was identical.

That night I repeated an experiment. In 1953, under a doctor's supervision, I had taken mescalin and spent hours marvelling at the folds of my trousers as though they were a miracle. This time I took a borrowed telephone to bed in my hotel room and opened one of those applications that show you short films, one after another, without end. I meant to observe for an hour what happened to me. At the end, on the notepad beside the bed, stood three words in my own handwriting: *Cat. Politician. Why?* Almost two hours had passed. I would have sworn it had been twenty minutes.

Then I understood where I had been mistaken. Soma, the happiness drug of my novel, has not been found as a substance. It has been built as a procedure, and built so that it never satisfies, for whoever is sated puts the telephone down. My brave new world, for all its cruelty, was a world of contented people. This one is a world of the restless. They pay the price and do not receive the goods.

You are reading these lines, I imagine, on a screen, perhaps between two videos. I do not reproach you for it. I was no better that night.

One afternoon in a cemetery I sat down beside an old woman who was looking at a gravestone, with no telephone, no book, no hurry. Her husband had died in the spring. Her children had installed an application for her

that was supposed to help with grief. ‘I don’t even want to feel better,’ she said. ‘I want to be allowed to miss him.’

Before I left, I closed my ledger. On one side stood what I had foreseen correctly: that people can love a comfortable servitude, and that their appetite for distraction is almost infinite. On the other side stood my errors. I had set my brave new world in the twenty-sixth century, and much of it arrived half a millennium early, if in a different shape. I had believed that those who love their servitude would at least be content. And around 1930 I had toyed in newspaper articles with the idea of breeding better human beings, even as my own novel was mocking it. Of that I am ashamed.

The two sides balance. A prophet whose ledger balances is no longer a prophet. He is a witness. He may report what he has seen, and then he must be silent, so that others can look for themselves.

On the last morning I sat in a train again. Again the heads were bowed, again the thumbs pushed onwards, again nobody looked out. Opposite me sat a young mother with her daughter, a girl of five or six. Suddenly the girl pressed her nose to the glass and cried: ‘Mummy, look! There’s a bird standing in the water!’

It was a heron. Perhaps the same one I had seen on the first day.

The mother looked up. For three seconds, perhaps four, there lay on her face an expression I had seldom seen in these days: not entertainment, not outrage, not desire, but simple, quiet wonder. Then she said, 'Yes, lovely,' and looked back at her telephone.

Three seconds are not much. No metric captures them. But sometimes they are enough to remind one that there is a world which does not take place on a screen.

In my last novel I invented an island where trained birds sit in the trees and call out a single word, over and over: *Attention.* Sometimes they add: *Here and now.* The German language, among whose speakers I spent these days, possesses a word for which I envy it. English readers know it chiefly from war films, barked by sentries. The word is *Achtung.* It is the cry of the warner who shouts at a danger. It is the summons to look. And it is what one human being owes another when he treats him not as a customer, not as an opponent and not as a spectator, but as a human being.

I came back intending to greet my contemporaries with the first of these three calls. I leave with the second and the third.

Achtung. Here and now.

This foretaste tells only of the first day and the last. What happened in between is merely hinted at here, and the most uncomfortable part is missing altogether. The full essay of the same title asks who actually steers the machine and why nobody stops it. It asks why we are so eager to find a villain, and how much of the responsibility lies with the powerful and how much with each of us, with our pensions, our telephones and our thumbs. It takes about an hour to read: less than Huxley's night in the hotel bed.

Huxley's return is fictional. The details of his life and work follow the historical record. Concept, selection and editing: Essah. Written in dialogue with Claude, an AI made by Anthropic. Huxley would have appreciated the irony.



Translated from the German original
Dir ist sie neu – Vorgeschmack

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